MANAGING SENSORY OVERWHELM

for Neurodivergent Adults

From Sensory Overwhelm
to Taking Back Control

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WELCOME

Hi There!

Welcome, and congratulations on taking a step toward making a life that works better for you!

As neurodivergent people, we're usually not given what we need to be and support our authentic selves. The world is full of ableist social standards that don't make room for our unique needs and ways of being.

Although there are some things about the world that we can't control, there is a lot that we can do to create and maintain lives that are full of meaning and value. One of the ways that neurodivergent people can manage our energy levels is by ensuring that our home is sensory-friendly and matches our needs.

It is essential for our well-being that feelings of overwhelm and overload are managed. This can be really tricky to figure out if you're already in the midst of overwhelm. But even taking small steps toward improving your sensory experience can make HUGE changes in the long-term.

This guide is here to support you as you take your next steps toward a better life. You deserve a home that feels good, safe, and welcoming. Let's go!

WANT TO GO DEEPER?

If you are struggling to take action, but you know having less overwhelm in your life would solve a lot of problems (truthfully!), let us help! Head over to the website, www.neurodiverging.com, to find out how to connect in an upcoming class or program, or email us directly at contact@neurodivergin.com with a little bit about what's going on for you right now.

You only get one life. Live it well!

Learn More

Understanding Your Triggers: Sound

Are there noises in your home that bother you? Take a couple of minutes to identify anything you can hear now, or anything you remember hearing in the past week, that has caused you distress.

Creating a Plan: Sound

Looking over the triggers you identified on the previous page, consider whether any of the following supports might be helpful.

☐ **Noise Dampening**

- Add carpets or area rugs to absorb noise.
- Insulate windows and add insulation to walls to absorb noise.
- Add vinyl acoustic window films to absorb noise.
- Add soft furniture, pillows, and blankets to absorb noise.
- Add soundproof curtains, tapestries, or canvas paintings to absorb noise.
- Add acoustic foam panels, sound-absorbing fabric panels, and/or acoustic partitions in high-noise areas

☐ **Personal Sensory Support**

- Use personal earplugs like Vibes or Loops
- Invest in good noise reduction ear muffs or noise-canceling headphone
- Buy a cheap 10-pack of foam earplugs to put in your car, backpack, briefcase, purse, or anywhere you may need them
- Consider a white noise machine in or directly outside your room

☐ **Any additional ideas to explore?**

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Understanding Your Triggers: Vision

Are there lights, colors, or visual clutter in your home that bother you? Take a couple of minutes to identify anything you notice now, or anything you remember noticing in the past week, that has caused you distress.

Creating a Plan: Vision

Looking over the triggers you identified on the previous page, consider whether any of the following supports might be helpful.

☐ **Electric Lights**

- Reduce fluorescent overhead lighting wherever possible, or switch them out for warm lights instead
- Add lamps, dimmer switches, or twinkle lights
- Use switch timers to turn lights on and off throughout the day
- Consider adding sunglasses or tinted glasses to your sensory kit

☐ **Colors and Patterns**

- Add paint, art, posters, or tapestries to the walls in colors and patterns that feel calming to you
- Remove or cover paint, art, etc. that create stress

☐ **Clutter**

- Do a sweep: can you donate, recycle, or throw away anything?
- Add bins or containers to add structure to your belonging
- Create homes for belongings so you know where they go once you're done using them
- Add labels to drawers, cabinets, bins, etc. so you know what's inside them

☐ **Any additional ideas to explore?**

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Understanding Your Triggers: Tactile

Are there textures or other tactile sensory experiences in your home that bother you? Take a couple of minutes to identify anything you remember touching or doing with your hands in the past week that has caused you distress.

Creating a Plan: Tactile

Looking over the triggers you identified on the previous page, consider whether any of the following supports might be helpful.

☐ **Everyday tasks and high-use items**

- Replace or adjust items of clothing, shoes, etc. that cause distress
- Insulate windows and add insulation to walls to absorb noise.
- Replace or adjust your cleaning tools, detergents, sprays, etc. to avoid skin irritation or sensory overwhelm
- Assess your towels, washcloths, blankets, bed linens, etc.
- Use things that feel good to you!

☐ **Personal Sensory Support**

- Consider whether gloves of any kind would help you
- Consider using a weighted blanket or lap bad to calm your nervous system
- Access deep pressure whenever you can (swimming, joint compressions, compression garments
- Consider working with an occupational therapist

☐ **Any additional ideas to explore?**

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Creating A Plan: Taste

Eating well is essential, but it needs to be enjoyable too. If there are certain foods that you struggle with, replace them with foods you do like that have similar nutritional value where possible.. Find food that you love so that mealtimes are a good experience for you.

If you are having a particularly difficult day, have some “safe meals” available. These are meals that involve little preparation that you enjoy. What are some safe foods that you could make available? Write them below.

Creating a Plan: Scent

There are many smells in the world that we can't always control. Are there smells that you do like? Are there ways you can reduce unwanted smells and add in good smells? Write down some thoughts here.

Finalizing Your Plan

Go back through this booklet and consider what you've learned about your personal sensory needs, and what you could add or remove from your daily life to improve your overall experience.

Write a sentence or two about what you can change this week to better support yourself, and why you want to do it.

What will this change give you?

And what will this give you?

So, why is this change important?

Feeling Safe and Secure

Remember that your goal is to create a safe and comfortable space for yourself.

If there are aspects of your home that are out of your control, consider starting in one room first. This may be your bedroom, your bed, or a corner of your desk.

Perhaps you eliminate an area of clutter. Maybe you add a blanket to your bed that has a soft texture. You might even remove an item in your bedroom that is causing you to feel overwhelmed.

Small changes to your space can help you manage your feelings of overwhelm and welcome in feelings of calm and rest. Creating a sensory-friendly space in your home is important for you and those around you.

If you need more help creating a better life, feel free to contact Neurodiverging Coaching to find out how we can support you.

Now, get out there and make a change!

Thank you!

Bonus: Recommended Products

Below are some products for sensory support recommended by our coaches. Some of these are affiliate links and we may earn a small commission from your purchase at no additional cost to you. We only recommend products we have actually tried and tested ourselves.

Sound:

- Danielle's post of recommended ear plugs and protection.
- Soundproof curtains
- Sound-absorbing foam panels
- Sound-absorbing doorway barrier
- White noise machine

Vision:

- Glasses for glare reduction
- Wire bins for organization

Touch:

- Weighted blanket
- Weighted lap pad
- Compression garments

FURTHER RESOURCES

Visit Neurodiverging.com

Join Our Free Community Group

Recommended Reading on Sensory Processing Challenges

Recommended Reading on Neurodiversity and Fatigue